

# “The philosopher escapes from the Cave only to be compelled to return.” Discuss.

## Preamble

In analysing Socrates' analogies, it is difficult to discern between analysis that produces elucidation and an insight into the character's philosophy, and analysis that diverges from the purpose of the allegory. Therefore, I think it will be useful to employ the heuristic that, the greatest elucidation will be achieved from addressing apparent contradictions in the allegory and details that seem unnecessary upon initial observation, but make an impression on us. The translation used is the Grube translation, revised by Reeve.

## Introduction

The aim of this essay is to analyse the allegory of the Cave presented in Book VII of Republic to argue for one possible interpretation of the mechanism by which the 'human being' [514a] sees the form of the good. This proposed mechanism must, at least, also be able to explain why it is that the human being is compelled to return to the prisoners.

## Carriers and Compellers

Perhaps the most intriguing detail of the allegory of the Cave is that of the “carriers” of the artifacts. Followed closely by the identity of those who compel the prisoners. Interestingly, it is never explicitly stated that these two groups of actors are the same. Furthermore, Socrates states:

“But when they've made it and looked sufficiently, we mustn't allow them to do what they're allowed to do today ... to stay there and refuse to go down again to the prisoners...” 519d

Therefore, we can conclude that the prisoners are not compelled return to the cave by the mechanism that compels them to leave the cave. In other words, the compellers only ever force the prisoners out of the cave but never back in. For the human beings to return to the cave, they must be acted on by a force which has so far been absent, that force being Socrates. I will return to this topic later as further progress requires that I return to the beginning and analyse the conditions of the bondage of the prisoners.

To be clear, Socrates never explicitly states that the compellers, nor the carriers, are responsible for keeping the prisoners captive. Furthermore, Socrates never states that the prisoners are literally bonded with chains, only that:

“They've been there since childhood, fixed in the same place ... their bonds prevent them from turning their heads around.” 514b

To explain how the prisoners are kept captive despite not being chained and only being aided by the carriers and compellers, I introduce the tripartite soul. It is my position that the carriers, the compellers, and the chains, are hallucinations of some of the prisoners. Further explanation requires a discussion of the tripartite soul.

## The Tripartite Soul

One can only escape the Cave of ignorance and enter the intelligible realm if their nature permits for their rational inclination to overpower their spirit and appetite.

The two competing models of the tripartite soul that I am familiar with are the view of the rational component as a referee, and the view of desire which is the view that I hold.

The referee model states that reason is the component which is responsible for keeping our spirit and appetite in check, to keep them at an optimal level which keeps us happy. This model enjoys the advantage of supporting our intuitive understanding of reason standing in opposition to irrational pride and carnal pleasures.

The desire model states that each component of the soul has a fluctuating desire of its own, or 'appetite'. The appetitive component has an appetite for food which is at its greatest when we are most hungry and satisfied when we have sufficiently eaten for that desire to be satisfied. Similarly for pride, one may undergo a great resurgence in their pride in response to being shamed – our spirit's appetite. This model holds that our rational component is no different and that the appetite of our reason is curiosity. I believe that this model is more accurate because it admits that reason does not benefit from a privilege in people's decision making. Rather, people are compelled to act in the ways that they do because the components of their soul are each pulling in different directions. This model explains how we can act in ways that bring us suffering. For example, we can shoot out of bed in the morning out of a spirited desire to seize the day despite desiring the comfort of our warm and soft beds because our spirit has overcome our appetite<sup>1</sup>.

## Back to the Cave

Applying the desire model of the tripartite soul to the Cave, we can interpret the following:

The carriers are a hallucination caused by the rational component of the prisoner's soul, which represent desire, or the appetite, of the rational component – which is curiosity. Similarly, the compeller is a hallucination representing our acting on our curiosity. Consider a prisoner, wishing to remain comfortable in the cave with which he is so familiar. He is afraid of leaving the Cave and he is holding onto a dishonest belief that he is satisfied with his current circumstances anyway; because he would be ashamed to see the form of the good and be forced to compare it with his own soul. However, the desire of his rational component, which is in constant flux, wishes to leave the Cave and observe the good more directly than by the weak flames of the fire, which can only form a silhouette. At some point in time, when the appetite of the rational component has been so starved, and it is in the nature of that human being to be extraordinarily rational, the rational component overpowers the spirit and appetite. Despite apparently having chosen to get up, the human being cannot so easily control the different fluctuating desires of his soul. Therefore, the human being feels compelled to have done something which is unexpected and something which remains painful, as it is not something they entirely wish to do. Socrates says that the prisoners would be 'pained and irritated' 516a, like someone constantly pushing back some activity which they know they should do. The overpowering of the rational component over the spirit and appetite is reflected in the ripping apart of the chains and the freeing of the necks and legs of the prisoners. However, there was no reference in the allegory to literal chains which could be ripped apart. It seems that we have imagined much more than Socrates has required, that we have hallucinated the chains, like the

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<sup>1</sup> I think the tripartite soul would have greater explanatory power if the appetite component was broadened to 'sensation', as it would include all carnal pleasures which are not food – leaving non-carnal pleasures to be distinguished as either rational or irrational (spirited).

prisoners. Extending this analysis to the rest of the allegory, we realise that we have hallucinated the compellers.

It is notable that we have less of a reason to believe that the carriers are hallucinated than the compellers, as Socrates states that they are people:

“Some of the carriers are talking, and some are silent”. 515c,

The compellers however, have a much more intimate role with the prisoners than the carriers. I believe this distinction was made to place a great emphasis on the agency of the individual as one who chooses to follow their path out of the cave and become a philosopher. Therefore, anything resembling compulsion in the Cave, which ‘overpowers’ or ‘bonds’ us, occurs within the individual person, and it is not caused by Socrates himself, who is external to that person. Having now discussed the prisoners, the carriers, and the compellers, I will now discuss the significance of the path.

## The Paths

Socrates states:

“behind [the prisoners], but on higher ground, there is a path stretching between them and the fire” 514b.

But previously Socrates states:

“an underground, cavelike dwelling, with an entrance a long way up, which is both open to the light and as wide as the cave itself.” 514a.

If the entrance is as wide as the cave itself, and it is open to light such that the light of the sun can be seen from the position of the fire and where all the artifacts are kept, we can infer that the cave is unobstructed from the entrance to the end wall, where the prisoners are positioned. This means that a near-infinite number of paths can be taken from the fire to the entrance of the cave.

Therefore, we can split the path taken of a prisoner who goes to the entrance into two paths: the first being necessarily direct and the second being not-necessarily direct. It is also notable that when the philosopher returns from the entrance to back to the other prisoners, he can take any route from the entrance to the fire, even a different one from the one he took to get up to the entrance, but his path from the fire to the prisoners must be direct.

Therefore, it must be easiest for the prisoner to reach the fire which does not burn brightly, than it is for him to reach the entrance of the cave which causes him to be “pained and irritated” as his eyes adapt to the sunlight.

However, Socrates also states:

“Imagine that along this path a low wall has been built, like the screen in front of puppeteers above which they show their puppets” 514b.

The only path which is available to the prisoners in their journey out of the cave is obstructed by the carriers. This means that it is easier to enter the cave than it is to exit, as it is easier to leap from a low wall than it is to climb over one. It is also easier to reach the prisoners from the entrance than it is for the prisoners to reach the entrance because the entire cave, including the path and the free-area past the fire which has no path, is on an incline – therefore the prisoners must exert themselves more than the philosopher.

## Mechanism by which the philosopher returns

If the philosopher is compelled to leave the cave by fluctuations of desires in his soul, he must be compelled to return to the prisoners the same way. Returning to the concept of the appetites of each component, we remember that a soul no longer has an appetite once it is satisfied. Once seeing the form of the good, the rational component of the soul is satisfied and the philosopher no longer desires to see the good, in other words, he is no longer curious. Now his soul is absent of the rational desire to oppose spirit and appetite, therefore the philosopher is condemned to return down the cave and become a prisoner, rather than rule his fellow prisoners and create a good city. Eventually, when his rational component will have a sufficient curiosity, he will overpower his reason and appetite again and he will climb out of the cave.

One objection to this model is as follows. Keeping with the tripartite soul, we can interpret Socrates as rejecting the possibility of a philosopher having their curiosity satisfied with the form of the good because, as he says:

“the ones who get to this point are unwilling to occupy themselves with human affairs and that their souls are always pressing upwards, eager to spend their time above.” 517d.

Socrates' use of the word “eager” means that the curiosity of the philosopher never diminishes, but this seems to contradict the desire model of the tripartite soul, which predicts that the rational desire of the philosopher decreases as it is satisfied. We can reconcile the two, however, by recognising that our nature can radically change due to certain stimulus. For example, our sensational desire to smoke will radically increase if we ever take up smoking. Similarly, seeing the form of the good may radically change our rational desire by increasing it.

## Socrates on free will

It is my view that the allegory of the Cave carries a fatalistic attitude. The presence of a path on only a section of the journey from the prisoners to the entrance of the cave, can be interpreted as the destination of the journey being fixed, regardless of the path by which we arrive at that point. We are destined to arrive at that point because of the fluctuating desires that constitute our soul.

Furthermore, the compellers, which we human beings considered to be people at first, are the way by which the prisoners can conceive of their being freed. It has already been discussed that we may interpret the hallucination of the compellers as representing our acting on our curiosity. But they can also support a fatalistic view of the allegory. The compellers are people to which the prisoners attribute their being freed because they cannot conceive of the constant conflict in their soul between the desires of their soul. They are so incapable of identifying their own soul, that they must imagine someone else as responsible for their action. Furthermore, the human body would have been considered by far the most complex mechanism at the time. Therefore, the prisoner is reflecting his inner conflict, which is inaccessible by him, onto another which compares in mystery. The result is an experience that something external to us is compelling us to arrive at some fixed event. Similarly, we often interact with technologies that are far beyond our understanding, but our interaction itself does not reflect the entirety of the mystery – otherwise, we could not interact with the technology.

The paths and the compellers are similar in that they are ways of addressing the questions of how the prisoners physically leave and enter the cave, their journey taken and whether they are compelled respectively. Furthermore, they are similar in that they fail to address the question. For example, the paths do not stretch along the entire journey of the prisoner, and the compeller does

alone does not actually explain the mechanism by which the prisoner acts. This retreat from the question of 'how things actually happen' also occurs in the fatalistic attitude. The fatalistic attitude is a surrender to the endeavour of developing an understanding, and choosing to be satisfied with whatever happens, whether the prisoner is ever able to leave the cave or not.

## Conclusion

To summarise, the allegory of the Cave can be interpreted as being a fatalistic view of the tripartite soul. It says that, whichever path we choose, the events are determined as we will follow our desires which are determined by firstly our nature, and secondly our momentary satisfaction of our desires. Our nature being responsible for determining our greatest inclinations in our soul, be it sensation, spirit, or rationality. And our momentary satisfaction of our desires determining whether we will soon wish to satisfy our sensational desires again, or whether we wish to satisfy the appetite of our rational component, and climb out of the Cave of Ignorance.